

Chapter 29

A Letter From Home

EAR Katherine—

I Living among grand friends as you are doing now, I don't suppose you will care to hear any of our news; but as I always thought you were a sensible girl, perhaps you are a trifle less swollen-headed than I suppose. Everything goes on much the same here. There was great trouble about the new curate, who is scandalously high. In my view, he is neither more nor less than a Roman. Everybody has spoken to the Vicar about it, but you know what the Vicar is—all Christian charity and no proper spirit. I have had a lot of trouble with maids lately. That girl Annie was no good—skirts up to her knees and wouldn't wear sensible woollen stockings. Not one of them can bear being spoken to. I have had a lot of pain with my rheumatism one way and another, and Dr. Harris persuaded me to go and see a London specialist—a waste of three guineas and a railway fare, as I told him; but by waiting until Wednesday I managed to get a cheap return. The London doctor pulled a long face and talked all round about and never straight out, until I said to him, 'I'm a plain woman, Doctor, and I like things to be plainly stated. Is it cancer, or is it not?' And then, of course, he had to say it was. They say a year with care, and not too much pain, though I am sure I can bear pain as well as any other Christian woman. Life seems rather lonely at times, with most of my friends dead or gone before. I wish you were in St Mary Mead, my dear, and that

is a fact. If you hadn't come into this money and gone off into grand society, I would have offered you double the salary poor Jane gave you to come and look after me; but there—there's no good wanting what we can't get. However, if things should go ill with you—and that is always possible. I have heard no end of tales of bogus noblemen marrying girls and getting hold of their money and then leaving them at the church door. I dare say you are too sensible for anything of the kind to happen to you, but one never knows; and never having had much attention of any kind it might easily go to your head now. So just in case, my dear, remember there is always a home for you here; and though a plain-spoken woman I am a warm-hearted one too.

Your affectionate old friend,

AMELIA VINER.

P.S. I saw a mention of you in the paper with your cousin, Viscountess Tamplin, and I cut it out and put it with my cuttings. I prayed for you on Sunday that you might be kept from pride and vainglory.

Katherine read this characteristic epistle through twice, then she laid it down and stared out of her bedroom window across the blue waters of the Mediterranean. She felt a curious lump in her throat. A sudden wave of longing for St Mary Mead swept over her. So full of familiar, everyday, stupid little things—and yet—home. She felt very inclined to lay her head down on her arms and indulge in a real good cry.

Lenox, coming in at the moment, saved her.

'Hello, Katherine,' said Lenox. 'I say—what is the matter?'

'Nothing,' said Katherine, grabbing up Miss Viner's letter and thrusting it into her handbag.

'You looked rather queer,' said Lenox. 'I say—I hope you don't mind—I rang up your detective friend, M. Poirot, and asked him to lunch with us in Nice. I said you wanted to see him, as I thought he might not come for me.'
'Did you want to see him then?' asked Katherine.

'He had white hair. It may have been a wig, it may not. It fitted very well. But I do not think he was old. His walk was young, and so was his voice.'

'His voice?' said Poirot thoughtfully. 'Ah, his voice! Would you know it again, Mademoiselle Zia?'

'I might,' said the girl.

'You were interested in him, eh? It was that that took you to the keyhole?'

Zia nodded.

'Yes, yes. I was curious. One had heard so much—he is not the ordinary thief—he is more like a figure of history or romance.'

'Yes,' said Poirot thoughtfully, 'yes; perhaps so.'

'But it is not this that I meant to tell you,' said Zia. 'It was just one other little fact that I thought might be—well—useful to you.'

'Yes?' said Poirot encouragingly.

'The rubies, as I say, were handed over to my father here at Nice. I did not see the person who handed them over, but—'

'Yes?'

'I know one thing. *It was a woman.*'

There was another silence; then the girl said, 'My father gave you a hint the other day.'

'It was very kind of him.'

'I do not think,' said Zia slowly, 'that there is anything that I can add to that.'

If Poirot was disappointed he did not show it. Not a muscle of his face changed.

'*Eh bien!*' he said cheerfully, 'then we must talk of other things.'

And he proceeded to chat gaily. The girl was *distrait*, however, and her answers were mechanical and not always to the point. It was when they were approaching the Casino once more that she seemed to come to a decision.

'M. Poirot?'

'Yes, Mademoiselle?'

'I—I should like to help you if I could.'

'You are very amiable, Mademoiselle—very amiable.'

Again there was a pause. Poirot did not press her. He was quite content to wait and let her take her own time.

'Ah bah,' said Zia, 'after all, why should I not tell you? My father is cautious—always cautious in everything he says. But I know that with you it is not necessary. You have told us it is only the murderer you seek, and that you are not concerned over the jewels. I believe you. You were quite right when you guessed that we were in Nice because of the rubies. They have been handed over here according to plan. My father has them now. He gave you a hint the other day as to who our mysterious client was.'

'The Marquis?' murmured Poirot softly.

'Yes, the Marquis.'

'Have you ever seen the Marquis, Mademoiselle Zia?'

'Once,' said the girl. 'But not very well,' she added. 'It was through a keyhole.'

'That always presents difficulties,' said Poirot sympathetically, 'but all the same you saw him. You would know him again?'

Zia shook her head.

'He wore a mask,' she explained.

'Young or old?'

'Yes,' said Lenox. 'I have rather lost my heart to him. I never met a man before whose eyes were really green like a cat's.'

'All right,' said Katherine. She spoke listlessly. The last few days had been trying. Derek Kettering's arrest had been the topic of the hour, and the Blue Train Mystery had been thrashed out from every conceivable standpoint.

'I have ordered the car,' said Lenox, 'and I have told Mother some lie or other—unfortunately I can't remember exactly what; but it won't matter, as she never remembers. If she knew where we were going, she would want to come too, to pump M. Poirot.'

The two girls arrived at the Negresco to find Poirot waiting.

He was full of Gallic politeness, and showered so many compliments upon the two girls that they were soon helpless with laughter; yet for all that the meal was not a gay one. Katherine was dreamy and distracted, and Lenox made bursts of conversation, interspersed by silences. As they were sitting on the terrace sipping their coffee she suddenly attacked Poirot bluntly.

'How are things going? You know what I mean?'

Poirot shrugged his shoulders. 'They take their course,' he said.

'And you are just letting them take their course?'

He looked at Lenox a little sadly.

'You are young, Mademoiselle, but there are three things that cannot be hurried—*le bon Dieu*, Nature, and old people.'

'Nonsense!' said Lenox. 'You are not old.'

'Ah, it is pretty what you say there.'

'Here is Major Knighton,' said Lenox.

Katherine looked round quickly and then turned back again.

'He is with Mr. Van Aldin,' continued Lenox. 'There is something I want to ask Major Knighton about. I won't be a minute.'

Left alone together, Poirot bent forward and murmured to Katherine:

'You are *distrait*, Mademoiselle; your thoughts, they are far away, are they not?'

'Just as far as England, no farther.'

Guided by a sudden impulse, she took the letter she had received that morning and handed it across to him to read.

'That is the first word that has come to me from my old life; somehow or other—it hurts.'

He read it through and then handed it back to her. 'So you are going back to St Mary Mead?' he said slowly.

'No, I am not,' said Katherine; 'why should I?'

'Ah,' said Poirot, 'it is my mistake. You will excuse me one little minute.'

He strolled across to where Lenox Tamplin was talking to Van Aldin and Knighton. The American looked old and haggard. He greeted Poirot with a curt nod but without any other sign of animation.

As he turned to reply to some observation made by Lenox, Poirot drew Knighton aside.

'M. Van Aldin looks ill,' he said.

'Do you wonder?' asked Knighton. 'The scandal of Derek Kettering's arrest has about put the lid on things, as far as he is concerned. He is even regretting that he asked you to find out the truth.'

'He should go back to England,' said Poirot.

'We are going the day after to-morrow.'

'That is good news,' said Poirot.

He hesitated, and looked across the terrace to where Katherine was sitting.

'I wish,' he murmured, 'that you could tell Miss Grey that.'

'Tell her what?'

'That you—I mean that M. Van Aldin is returning to England.'

Knighton looked a little puzzled, but he readily crossed the terrace and joined Katherine.

Poirot saw him go with a satisfied nod of the head, and then joined Lenox and the American. After a minute or two they joined the others. Conversation was general for a few minutes, then the millionaire and his secretary departed. Poirot also prepared to take his departure.

'A thousand thanks for your hospitality, Mesdemoiselles,' he cried; 'it has been a most charming luncheon. *Ma foi*, I needed it!' He swelled out his chest and thumped it. 'I am now a lion—a giant. Ah, Mademoiselle Katherine, you have not seen me as I can be. You have seen the gentle, the calm Hercule Poirot; but there is another Hercule Poirot. I go now to bully, to threaten, to strike terror into the hearts of those who listen to me.'

He looked at them in a self-satisfied way, and they both appeared to be duly impressed, though Lenox was biting her under lip, and the corners of Katherine's mouth had a suspicious twitch.

Papopolous' possession. And since, as you say, Mademoiselle, the young are foolish and credulous, it was easy to believe him and to give him a sight of that particular thing, to show him where it was kept. And afterwards when it is gone—when the unbelievable catastrophe has happened. Alas! the poor little pensionnaire. What a terrible position she is in. She is frightened, the poor little one. To speak or not to speak? And then there comes along that excellent fellow, Hercule Poirot. Almost a miracle it must have been, the way things arranged themselves. The priceless heirlooms are restored and there are no awkward questions.'

Zia turned on him fiercely.

'You have known all the time? Who told you? Was it—was it Antonio?'

Poirot shook his head.

'No one told me,' he said quietly. 'I guessed. It was a good guess, was it not, Mademoiselle? You see, unless you are good at guessing, it is not much use being a detective.'

The girl walked along beside him for some minutes in silence. Then she said in a hard voice:

'Well, what are you going to do about it, are you going to tell my father?'

'No,' said Poirot sharply. 'Certainly not.'

She looked at him curiously.

'You want something from me?'

'I want your help, Mademoiselle.'

'What makes you think that I can help you?'

'I do not think so. I only hope so.'

'And if I do not help you, then—you will tell my father?'

'But no, but no! Debarrass yourself of that idea, Mademoiselle. I am not a blackmailer. I do not hold your secret over your head and threaten you with it.'

'If I refuse to help you—' began the girl slowly.

'Then you refuse, and that is that.'

'Then why—' she stopped.

'Listen, and I will tell you why. Women, Mademoiselle, are generous. If they can render a service to one who has rendered a service to them, they will do it. I was generous once to you, Mademoiselle. When I might have spoken, I held my tongue.'

thing, Mademoiselle. One is foolish to leave all that simply because one has no money—or because the heart aches. *L'amour*, it causes many fatalities, does it not?’

Zia laughed.

‘You should not laugh at love, Mademoiselle,’ said Poirot, shaking an energetic forefinger at her. ‘You who are young and beautiful.’

‘Hardly that,’ said Zia; ‘you forget that I am thirty-three, M. Poirot. I am frank with you, because it is no good being otherwise. As you told my father, it is exactly seventeen years since you aided us in Paris that time.’

‘When I look at you, it seems much less,’ said Poirot gallantly. ‘You were then very much as you are now, Mademoiselle, a little thinner, a little paler, a little more serious. Sixteen years old and fresh from your pension. Not quite the *petite pensionnaire*, not quite a woman. You were very delicious, very charming, Mademoiselle Zia; others thought so too, without doubt.’

‘At sixteen,’ said Zia, ‘one is simple and a little fool.’

‘That may be,’ said Poirot, ‘yes, that well may be. At sixteen one is credulous, is one not? One believes what one is told.’

If he saw the quick sideways glance that the girl shot at him, he pretended not to have done so. He continued dreamily: ‘It was a curious affair that, altogether. Your father, Mademoiselle, has never understood the true inwardness of it.’

‘No?’

‘When he asked me for details, for explanations, I said to him thus: “Without scandal, I have got back for you that which was lost. You must ask no questions.” Do you know, Mademoiselle, why I said these things?’

‘I have no idea,’ said the girl coldly.

‘It was because I had a soft spot in my heart for a little pensionnaire, so pale, so thin, so serious.’

‘I don’t understand what you are talking about,’ cried Zia angrily.

‘Do you not, Mademoiselle? Have you forgotten Antonio Pirezzio?’

He heard the quick intake of her breath—almost a gasp.

‘He came to work as an assistant in the shop, but not thus could he have got hold of what he wanted. An assistant can lift his eyes to his master’s daughter, can he not? If he is young and handsome with a glib tongue. And since they cannot make love all the time, they must occasionally talk of things that interest them both—such as that very interesting thing which was temporarily in M.

‘And I shall do it,’ he said gravely. ‘Oh yes, I shall succeed.’

He had gone but a few steps when Katherine’s voice made him turn.

‘M. Poirot, I—I want to tell you. I think you were right in what you said. I am going back to England almost immediately.’

Poirot stared at her very hard, and under the directness of his scrutiny she blushed.

‘I see,’ he said gravely.

‘I don’t believe you do,’ said Katherine.

‘I know more than you think, Mademoiselle,’ he said quietly.

He left her, with an odd little smile upon his lips. Entering a waiting car, he drove to Antibes.

Hippolyte, the Comte de la Roche’s wooden-faced man-servant, was busy at the Villa Marina polishing his master’s beautiful cut table glass. The Comte de la Roche himself had gone to Monte Carlo for the day. Chancing to look out of the window, Hippolyte espied a visitor walking briskly up to the hall door, a visitor of so uncommon a type that Hippolyte, experienced as he was, had some difficulty in placing him. Calling to his wife, Marie, who was busy in the kitchen, he drew her attention to what he called *ce type là*.

‘It is not the police again?’ said Marie anxiously.

‘Look for yourself,’ said Hippolyte.

Marie looked.

‘Certainly not the police,’ she declared. ‘I am glad.’

‘They have not really worried us much,’ said Hippolyte. ‘In fact, but for Monsieur le Comte’s warning, I should never have guessed that stranger at the wine-shop to be what he was.’

The hall bell pealed and Hippolyte, in a grave and decorous manner, went to open the door.

‘M. le Comte, I regret to say, is not at home.’

The little man with the large moustaches beamed placidly.

‘I know that,’ he replied. ‘You are Hippolyte Flavelle, are you not?’

‘Yes, Monsieur, that is my name.’

‘And you have a wife, Marie Flavelle?’

‘Yes, Monsieur, but—’

‘I desire to see you both,’ said the stranger, and he stepped nimbly past Hippolyte into the hall.

'Your wife is doubtless in the kitchen,' he said. 'I will go there.'

Before Hippolyte could recover his breath, the other had selected the right door at the back of the hall and passed along the passage and into the kitchen, where Marie paused open-mouthed to stare at him.

'*Voilà*,' said the stranger, and sank into a wooden arm-chair; 'I am Hercule Poirot.'

'Yes, Monsieur?'

'You do not know the name?'

'I have never heard it,' said Hippolyte.

'Permit me to say that you have been badly educated. It is the name of one of the great ones of this world.'

He sighed and folded his hands across his chest.

Hippolyte and Marie were staring at him uneasily. They were at a loss what to make of this unexpected and extremely strange visitor.

'Monsieur desires—' murmured Hippolyte mechanically.

'I desire to know why you have lied to the police.'

'Monsieur!' cried Hippolyte; 'I—lied to the police? Never have I done such a thing.'

M. Poirot shook his head.

'You are wrong,' he said; 'you have done it on several occasions. Let me see.' He took a small notebook from his pocket and consulted it. 'Ah, yes; on seven occasions at least. I will recite them to you.'

In a gentle unemotional voice he proceeded to outline the seven occasions. Hippolyte was taken aback.

'But it is not of these past lapses that I wish to speak,' continued Poirot, 'only, my dear friend, do not get into the habit of thinking yourself too clever. I come now to the particular lie in which I am concerned—your statement that the Comte de la Roche arrived at this villa on the morning of 14th January.'

'But that was no lie, Monsieur; that was the truth. Monsieur le Comte arrived here on the morning of Tuesday, the 14th. That is so, Marie, is it not?' Marie assented eagerly.

'Ah, yes, that is quite right. I remember it perfectly.'

'Ah,' said Poirot, 'and what did you give your good master for *déjeuner* that day?'

'I—' Marie paused, trying to collect herself.

Poirot's eyes twinkled.

'Superb!' he exclaimed. 'You are the daughter of your father, Mademoiselle Zia. To know when to stop. Ah! that is the art.'

He looked round the rooms.

'I cannot see your father anywhere about,' he remarked carelessly. 'I will fetch your cloak for you, Mademoiselle, and we will go out in the gardens.'

He did not, however, go straight to the cloak-room. His sharp eyes had seen but a little while before the departure of M. Papopolous. He was anxious to know what had become of the wily Greek. He ran him to earth unexpectedly in the big entrance hall. He was standing by one of the pillars, talking to a lady who had just arrived. The lady was Mirelle.

Poirot sidled unostentatiously round the room. He arrived at the other side of the pillar, and unnoticed by the two who were talking together in an animated fashion—or rather, that is to say, the dancer was talking, Papopolous contributing an occasional monosyllable and a good many expressive gestures. 'I tell you I must have time,' the dancer was saying. 'If you give me time I will get the money.'

'To wait?—the Greek shrugged his shoulders—'it is awkward.'

'Only a very little while,' pleaded the other. 'Ah! but you must! A week—ten days—that is all I ask. You can be sure of your affair. The money will be forthcoming.'

Papopolous shifted a little and looked round him uneasily—to find Poirot almost at his elbow with a beaming innocent face.

'*Ah! vous voilà*, M. Papopolous. I have been looking for you. It is permitted that I take Mademoiselle Zia for a little turn in the gardens? Good evening, Mademoiselle.' He bowed very low to Mirelle. 'A thousand pardons that I did not see you immediately.'

The dancer accepted his greetings rather impatiently. She was clearly annoyed at the interruption of her *tête-à-tête*. Poirot was quick to take the hint. Papopolous had already murmured: 'Certainly—but certainly,' and Poirot withdrew forthwith.

He fetched Zia's cloak, and together they strolled out into the gardens.

'This is where the suicides take place,' said Zia.

Poirot shrugged his shoulders. 'So it is said. Men are foolish, are they not, Mademoiselle? To eat, to drink, to breathe the good air, it is a very pleasant

'Some one who knows something?'

'Some one who might know something. In these matters one must leave no stone unturned. Au revoir, Mademoiselle.'

Lenox accompanied him to the door.

'Have I—helped?' she asked.

Poirot's face softened as he looked up at her standing on the doorstep above him.

'Yes, Mademoiselle, you have helped. If things are very dark, always remember that.'

When the car had driven off he relapsed into a frowning absorption, but in his eyes was that faint green light which was always the precursor of the triumph to be.

He was a few minutes late at the rendezvous, and found that M. Papopolous and his daughter had arrived before him. His apologies were abject, and he outdid himself in politeness and small attentions. The Greek was looking particularly benign and noble this evening, a sorrowful patriarch of blameless life. Zia was looking handsome and good humoured. The dinner was a pleasant one. Poirot was his best and most sparkling self. He told anecdotes, he made jokes, he paid graceful compliments to Zia Papopolous, and he told many interesting incidents of his career. The menu was a carefully selected one, and the wine was excellent.

At the close of dinner M. Papopolous inquired politely:

'And the tip I gave you? You have had your little flutter on the horse?'

'I am in communication with—er—my bookmaker,' replied Poirot.

The eyes of the two men met.

'A well-known horse, eh?'

'No,' said Poirot; 'it is what our friends, the English, call a dark horse.'

'Ah!' said M. Papopolous thoughtfully.

'Now we must step across to the Casino and have our little flutter at the roulette table,' cried Poirot gaily.

At the Casino the party separated, Poirot devoting himself solely to Zia, whilst Papopolous himself drifted away.

Poirot was not fortunate, but Zia had a run of good luck, and had soon won a few thousand francs.

'It would be as well,' she observed dilly to Poirot, 'if I stopped now.'

'Odd,' said Poirot, 'how one remembers some things—and forgets others.' He leant forward and struck the table a blow with his fist; his eyes flashed with anger.

'Yes, yes, it is as I say. You tell your lies and you think nobody knows. But there are two people who know. Yes—two people. One is *le bon Dieu*—'

He raised a hand to heaven, and then settling himself back in his chair and shutting his eyelids, he murmured comfortably:

'And the other is Hercule Poirot.'

'I assure you, Monsieur, you are completely mistaken. Monsieur le Comte left Paris on Monday night—'

'True,' said Poirot—'by the Rapide. I do not know where he broke his journey. Perhaps you do not know that. What I do know is that he arrived here on Wednesday morning, and not on Tuesday morning.'

'Monsieur is mistaken,' said Marie stolidly.

Poirot rose to his feet.

'Then the law must take its course,' he murmured. 'A pity.'

'What do you mean, Monsieur?' asked Marie, with a shade of uneasiness.

'You will be arrested and held as accomplices concerned in the murder of Mrs Kettering, the English lady who was killed.'

'Murder!'

The man's face had gone chalk white, his knees knocked together. Marie dropped the rolling-pin and began to weep.

'But it is impossible—impossible. I thought—'

'Since you stick to your story, there is nothing to be said. I think you are both foolish.'

He was turning towards the door when an agitated voice arrested him.

'Monsieur, Monsieur, just a little moment. I—I had no idea that it was anything of this kind. I—I thought it was just a matter concerning a lady. There have been little awkwardnesses with the police over ladies before. But murder—that is very different.'

'I have no patience with you,' cried Poirot. He turned round on them and angrily shook his fist in Hippolyte's face. 'Am I to stop here all day, arguing with a couple of imbeciles thus? It is the truth I want. If you will not give it to me, that is your look out. *For the last time, when did Monsieur le Comte arrive at the Villa Marina—Tuesday morning or Wednesday morning?*'

'Wednesday,' gasped the man, and behind him Marie nodded confirmation. Poirot regarded them for a minute or two, then inclined his head gravely.

'You are wise, my children,' he said quietly. 'Very nearly you were in serious trouble.'

He left the Villa Marina, smiling to himself.

'One guess, confirmed,' he murmured to himself. 'Shall I take a chance on the other?'

It was six o'clock when the card of Monsieur Hercule Poirot was brought up to Mirelle. She stared at it for a moment or two, and then nodded. When Poirot entered, he found her walking up and down the room feverishly. She turned on him furiously.

'Well?' she cried. 'Well? What is it now? Have you not tortured me enough, all of you? Have you not made me betray my poor Derek? What more do you want?'

Just one little question, Mademoiselle. After the train left Lyons, when you entered Mrs Kettering's compartment—'

'What is that?'

Poirot looked at her with an air of mild reproach and began again.

'I say when you entered Mrs Kettering's compartment—'

'I never did.'

'And found her—'

'I never did.'

'*Ah, sacré!*'

He turned on her in a rage and shouted at her, so that she cowered back before him.

'Will you lie to me? I tell you I know what happened as well as though I had been there. You went into her compartment and you found her dead. I tell you I know it. To lie to me is dangerous. Be careful, Mademoiselle Mirelle.'

Her eyes wavered beneath his gaze and fell.

'I—I didn't—' she began uncertainly and stopped.

'There is only one thing about which I wonder,' said Poirot—'I wonder, Mademoiselle, if you found what you were looking for or whether—'

'Whether what?'

'Or whether some one else had been before you.'

Lyons. And we know this much, that a few moments after leaving Lyons Mrs Kettering was dead.'

'How do you know that?'

Poirot was smiling rather oddly to himself.

'Some one else went into her compartment and found her dead.'

'And they did not rouse the train?'

'No.'

'Why was that?'

'Doubtless they had their reasons.'

Lenox looked at him sharply.

'Do you know the reason?'

'I think so—yes.'

Lenox sat still turning things over in her mind. Poirot watched her in silence. At last she looked up. A soft colour had come into her cheeks and her eyes were shining.

'You think some one on the train must have killed her, but that need not be so at all. What is to stop any one swinging themselves on to the train when it stopped at Lyons? They could go straight to her compartment, strangle her, and take the rubies and drop off the train again without any one being the wiser. She may have been actually killed while the train was in Lyons station. Then she would have been alive when Derek went in, and dead when the other person found her.'

Poirot leant back in his chair. He drew a deep breath. He looked across at the girl and nodded his head three times, then he heaved a sigh.

'Mademoiselle,' he said, 'what you have said there is very just—very true. I was struggling in darkness, and you have shown me a light. There was a point that puzzled me and you have made it plain.'

He got up.

'And Derek?' said Lenox.

'Who knows?' said Poirot, with a shrug of his shoulders. 'But I will tell you this, Mademoiselle. I am not satisfied; no, I, Hercule Poirot, am not yet satisfied. It may be that this very night I shall learn something more. At least, I go to try.'

'You are meeting some one?'

'Yes.'